

Forward Flux Sampling for Tropical Cyclogenesis in a Neural Weather Emulator

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Abstract

Tropical cyclone genesis is a rare atmospheric event whose probability varies by orders of magnitude across synoptic regimes, yet direct ensemble sampling cannot resolve this variability at operationally feasible ensemble sizes. This paper presents a *methods demonstration*: we show that Forward Flux Sampling (FFS), a non-equilibrium rare-event technique from statistical mechanics, can be efficiently coupled to a fast neural weather emulator (SDL-WXFormer, 1° resolution) to estimate conditional genesis rates without modifying model dynamics. The 1° emulator is chosen deliberately for computational tractability — FFS requires $\mathcal{O}(10^4)$ model trajectories per initial condition — and its calibrated stochastic layers provide the ensemble spread the method requires. FFS decomposes the rare $A \rightarrow B$ transition into a flux through an initial interface and a product of conditional crossing probabilities across four shooting interfaces, exploiting the natural parallelism of the shooting phase. Applied to 98 Atlantic basin initial conditions spanning August 21 – October 8, 2022, FFS resolves genesis rates spanning nearly three orders of magnitude (2.6×10^{-5} to 1.7×10^{-2} events day^{-1}), capturing a clear seasonal cycle consistent with observed 2022 Atlantic activity. Internal validation — comparing FFS rates to independent direct-sampling rates from the same flux trajectories — yields a mean ratio of 1.03 ± 0.15 (range 0.71–1.52) across all 98 initial conditions, confirming self-consistent implementation of the conditional probability factorization within this model. Computational enhancement factors range from $3\times$ (most active environment) to $140\times$ (most suppressed), with a geometric mean of $14\times$. Three case studies illustrate the physical diagnostics the method provides: the rate-limiting step is initial tropical organization for the Earl environment, uniformly high crossing probabilities for the Fiona precursor environment, and a compound barrier at the final intensification stages for the Ian precursor. The methodology is independent of model architecture and extends directly to higher-resolution physics-based systems.

1 Introduction

Tropical cyclone genesis represents one of the most consequential rare events in atmospheric science. Approximately 10–15% of Atlantic tropical disturbances develop into named systems [Frank, 1970,

Landsea, 1998], but discriminating developing from non-developing cases challenges deterministic and ensemble approaches alike [Titley and Elsberry, 2000, Halperin et al., 2013]. The computational challenge is fundamental: for a genesis event with probability $p \sim 10^{-3}$ per day and target relative uncertainty of 20%, direct Monte Carlo estimation requires $\mathcal{O}(10^4)$ ensemble members per initial condition, far exceeding operational budgets.

Rare event sampling techniques address this by concentrating computational effort on transition pathways rather than waiting for rare events to occur spontaneously. The atmospheric rare-event literature has converged on Adaptive Multilevel Splitting (AMS) and variants as primary tools [Ragone et al., 2018, Webber et al., 2019, Finkel et al., 2024]. These methods efficiently generate ensembles of rare trajectory *realizations*. Forward Flux Sampling [Allen et al., 2006, 2009] occupies a complementary niche: it is designed specifically to estimate steady-state *rates* — expected transitions per unit time — with decomposed uncertainty that reveals which intensification stage is rate-limiting. For hurricane genesis, the operational question is not merely what a genesis event looks like but *how frequently* it occurs under a given atmospheric state. FFS delivers this directly.

FFS was developed for non-equilibrium steady-state (NESS) systems and requires no equilibrium assumptions: no free energy landscapes, detailed balance, or Boltzmann distributions. The method needs only well-defined metastable regions, measurable flux through interfaces, and Markovian dynamics [Allen et al., 2009], and has been applied across molecular and biophysical contexts including nucleic acid folding kinetics [Schreck et al., 2015]. The atmosphere is a canonical NESS system — driven by solar forcing, dissipated by radiation and friction — and satisfies all three conditions. Atmospheric rare events are dynamical transitions between regions of a strange attractor, not thermodynamic transitions over energy barriers [Touchette, 2009]. This makes FFS *more* defensible for atmospheric applications than equilibrium-based rare event techniques.

An important interpretive point: FFS genesis rates vary by three orders of magnitude across the 98 initial conditions studied here, reflecting strongly non-stationary background conditions across the hurricane season. The quantity k computed for each initial condition should therefore be understood as a *conditional genesis rate given the atmospheric state at that IC*, not a climatological steady-state rate. Each FFS simulation treats a 10–15 day forecast window anchored to a specific ERA5 state as a locally-stationary system, and the resulting k characterizes the genesis probability density in that particular atmospheric environment. This conditional framing — analogous to a conditional return period given present climate state [Finkel et al., 2024] — is the appropriate interpretation and motivates the full seasonal sampling across 98 ICs.

Machine learning weather models [Lam and Coauthors, 2023, Bi and Coauthors, 2023, Pathak and Coauthors, 2022] offer a natural platform for rare event sampling: they are $\sim 1000\times$ faster than physics-based models, natively generate ensemble spread through learned stochasticity, and inherit the attractor structure of the training data. The SDL-WXFormer [Schreck and Coauthors, 2024] extends this with stochastic decomposition layers calibrated to ERA5 ensemble statistics, making it suitable for the large trajectory counts required by FFS.

Scope and model choice. This paper is primarily a *methods demonstration*: we establish

that FFS can be coupled to a fast neural emulator to produce physically interpretable genesis rate estimates, and characterize the method’s behaviour across a full hurricane season. We deliberately use SDL-WXFormer at 1° resolution rather than a convection-permitting physics-based model for two practical reasons. First, FFS is computationally demanding: each initial condition requires $\mathcal{O}(10^4)$ 15-day trajectories, and at ~ 1.5 GPU-minutes per forecast on an NVIDIA A100, the full 98-IC dataset required approximately 2,450 GPU-hours. A comparable experiment with WRF or IFS would be prohibitively expensive on available allocations. Second, the SDL-WXFormer’s calibrated stochastic decomposition layers provide the ensemble variability the FFS shooting phase requires; a deterministic neural emulator would collapse all branching probabilities to zero or one. The 1° resolution imposes a well-understood limitation: the model cannot faithfully reproduce Category 3+ intensity or convective-scale vortex dynamics, so state B is defined at 975 hPa (tropical storm to minimal hurricane) rather than the intensities typical of major hurricane development. This limitation is consistent with the paper’s methodological focus, and the framework transfers directly to higher-resolution systems as compute budgets permit.

This paper reports: (1) a three-order-of-magnitude seasonal cycle in conditional genesis rates consistent with observed 2022 Atlantic activity; (2) internal self-consistency validation showing FFS and direct-sampling rates agree within a mean ratio of 1.03 ± 0.15 across 98 initial conditions; (3) case studies illustrating physically distinct rate-limiting steps; and (4) a Cyclone Phase Space contamination screen separating tropical from extratropical development pathways.

2 Methods

2.1 Forward Flux Sampling

FFS estimates the transition rate from metastable state A (unorganized disturbances, $Q > \lambda_A$) to state B (organized tropical cyclone, $Q \leq \lambda_B$) by factorizing:

$$k_{A \rightarrow B}^{\text{FFS}} = \Phi_{A,0} \times \prod_{i=1}^n P(\lambda_i | \lambda_{i-1}) \quad (1)$$

where $\Phi_{A,0} = N_{\text{cross}}/T_{\text{total}}$ is the flux of trajectories crossing the first interface λ_0 per unit time, and $P(\lambda_i | \lambda_{i-1})$ is the conditional probability that a trajectory at λ_{i-1} reaches λ_i before returning to A . The order parameter $Q(\mathbf{x})$ is the minimum sea-level pressure (MSLP) within the Atlantic basin domain $\Omega = [10^\circ\text{N}, 40^\circ\text{N}] \times [100^\circ\text{W}, 20^\circ\text{W}]$.

State definitions and interfaces. State A : $Q > \lambda_A = 1008$ hPa (unorganized synoptic disturbances). State B : $Q \leq \lambda_B = 975$ hPa AND warm-core structure satisfied (CPS criterion) AND vortex centre within the basin domain Ω . We note that 975 hPa corresponds to tropical storm to minimal hurricane intensity and is *intentionally stronger* than the conventional NHC tropical storm genesis designation (~ 34 kt, roughly 997–1003 hPa in typical Atlantic pressure–wind relationships). At 1° resolution, the model’s smoothed MSLP field does not develop a reliable closed isobar signature until the vortex is more strongly organised than the standard genesis threshold;

975 hPa is the lowest pressure at which state- B arrivals cluster in physically expected geographic locations and pass the CPS warm-core screen with consistent reliability. The compound criterion means that reaching the 975 hPa MSLP threshold is necessary but not sufficient for state B ; trajectories that deepen to 975 hPa while recurving poleward or exiting the domain are not counted as state- B arrivals, and $P_4 = P(B|\lambda_4) < 1$ reflects this screening. The 975 hPa threshold is calibrated to the SDL-WXFormer’s 1° horizontal resolution through trial experiments. The flux interface and four shooting interfaces are:

$$\lambda_0 = 1000.0, \quad \lambda_1 = 987.2, \quad \lambda_2 = 984.7, \quad \lambda_3 = 981.2, \quad \lambda_4 = \lambda_B = 975.0 \quad [\text{hPa}]$$

satisfying $\lambda_A > \lambda_0 > \lambda_1 > \dots > \lambda_4 = \lambda_B$. The interfaces and thresholds stated here are those used to produce all results in this paper and match the configuration file in the public code repository (`config/ffs.yml`; <https://github.com/NCAR/miles-tails>). Note that `forecast_start_times` in that file lists only the three case-study ICs; the full 98-IC seasonal run was launched via the PBS job scripts in `applications/run_paper_figures_mar18.sh`.

Notation. We label the four conditional crossing probabilities P_1 – P_4 in order of the FFS product: $P_1 = P(\lambda_2|\lambda_1)$, $P_2 = P(\lambda_3|\lambda_2)$, $P_3 = P(\lambda_4|\lambda_3)$, and $P_4 = P(B|\lambda_4)$. The $\lambda_0 \rightarrow \lambda_1$ transition is implicit in the flux $\Phi_{A,0}$ and is not a shooting interface; P_1 therefore refers to the *first shooting* step (987.2 $\rightarrow$ 984.7 hPa), not the first interface crossing from A .

Interface placement. Shooting interfaces are chosen using the optimal- $1/e$ rule of Allen et al. [2009]: the next interface λ_{i+1} is placed at the p^* -quantile of the MSLP distribution reached by trajectories launched from λ_i , where $p^* = 1/e \approx 0.368$. This placement minimises variance in the estimated rate and targets conditional crossing probabilities near $1/e$, maximising statistical efficiency [Allen et al., 2009]. In practice, interfaces were optimized from long trial runs and then rounded to physically interpretable pressure values; the resulting P_i values (Table 1) cluster between 0.10 and 0.91 across all ICs, with a majority in the well-conditioned range 0.25–0.75 as shown in Figure 5.

Flux estimation. For each initial condition we generate trajectories from the ERA5 state perturbed by SDL-WXFormer stochastic layers, advancing 6-hourly for up to 15 days. Decorrelated λ_0 crossings (requiring return to state A between consecutive crossings) are accumulated to $N_{\text{cross}} = 2000$ per initial condition, yielding Poisson uncertainty $\sigma_\Phi/\Phi \approx 2.2\%$ — well below across-IC variability. State- B arrivals during flux generation provide an independent direct-sampling rate $k^{\text{direct}} = N_{\text{direct}}/T_{\text{total}}$ that serves as internal validation.

Shooting. Configurations saved at λ_0 seed shooting trajectories toward each successive interface. For each interface λ_{i-1} , trajectories are launched until 2000 successful crossings of λ_i are accumulated. Success probability $P(\lambda_i|\lambda_{i-1}) = N_{\text{success}}/N_{\text{attempts}}$ with binomial uncertainty. Statistical uncertainty on the full rate (Eq. 1) propagates from each factor:

$$\frac{\sigma_k}{k} = \sqrt{\left(\frac{\sigma_\Phi}{\Phi}\right)^2 + \sum_{i=1}^n \left(\frac{\sigma_{P_i}}{P_i}\right)^2} \quad (2)$$

2.2 SDL-WXFormer and Experimental Setup

SDL-WXFormer [Schreck and Coauthors, 2024] is a vision transformer trained on ERA5 reanalysis (1979–2021) at 1° resolution, 6-hour timesteps, predicting 69 pressure-level and 8 surface variables. Stochastic decomposition layers inject learned, state-dependent noise enabling calibrated ensemble generation. Each 10-day forecast requires ≈ 1.5 GPU-minutes on NVIDIA A100.

We select 98 initial conditions from ERA5 at 00 and 12 UTC spanning August 21 – October 8, 2022, verifying $Q(\mathbf{x}_0) > 1008$ hPa for each. Three initial conditions receive detailed case study treatment:

- **2022-09-02T00Z (Earl)**: ~ 24 hours before Hurricane Earl’s official tropical-storm genesis on September 3.
- **2022-09-09T12Z (active)**: highest observed FFS genesis rate in the dataset, within the Fiona precursor environment (~ 5 days before Fiona’s formation).
- **2022-09-22T00Z (Ian precursor)**: 24 hours before Hurricane Ian’s NHC genesis designation on September 23.

2.3 Feature Tracking and Tropical Contamination Screen

We emphasise at the outset that both the vortex tracker and the warm-core screen described below are purpose-built, ad-hoc components calibrated for the SDL-WXFormer at 1° resolution. They were sufficient to demonstrate that FFS produces self-consistent genesis rates in this setting, which is the goal of this methods demonstration. Production-quality implementations at other resolutions or with other models will require state-of-the-art objective trackers (e.g., TempestExtremes, TRACK, or similar) and a formally validated tropical classification scheme; the present implementations should not be adopted uncritically for other applications.

Flux mode (multi-storm tracking). During the flux phase, the order parameter Q is the global minimum MSLP over the basin domain Ω , which may correspond to any co-existing tropical system. To track this minimum coherently across timesteps, we maintain a running list of all active vortex candidates. At each 6-hour step, Gaussian smoothing ($\sigma = 1.5$ grid-points) is applied to the MSLP field and local minima below 1010 hPa are detected. Existing tracks are updated by nearest-neighbour matching within 12° ; unmatched minima below 12°N over land are suppressed (terrain artefacts); remaining unmatched minima seed new tracks. A track is retained for up to two consecutive timesteps of failed matching before being dropped. This scheme simultaneously follows multiple co-existing systems and switches the designated “minimum” when a new system deepens below the current one, preserving a well-defined monotone order parameter throughout the flux phase.

Shoot mode (single-vortex tracking). Once a trajectory has been saved at λ_0 and begins the shooting phase, the target vortex is the one that triggered the λ_0 crossing. At each timestep, the MSLP minimum is sought within 12° of the vortex’s last known position. This single-vortex

constraint prevents Q from jumping to a stronger but unrelated system, ensuring that the shooting trajectory measures the intensification of the specific disturbance seeded at λ_0 .

Tropical contamination screen. An empirically-calibrated contamination screen, inspired by the Cyclone Phase Space framework of Hart [2003], suppresses two known sources of spurious state- B arrivals at 1° resolution: (1) terrain-induced MSLP minima from hydrostatic extrapolation errors, and (2) mid-latitude baroclinic cyclones entering the domain. The screen evaluates the thermal wind parameters $-V_T^L$ and $-V_T^U$ at λ_0 crossings and when a tracked vortex exceeds 50°N or -10°W , rejecting systems with $-V_T^L > 0$ or $-V_T^U > 0$. The rejection thresholds were calibrated by manual inspection of a subset of trajectories in the 2022 dataset that were visually identifiable as extratropical (recurving systems and baroclinic cyclones intruding from the northwest); they are not derived from formal CPS validation at this resolution and should be treated as engineering choices rather than physical thresholds. The screen errs toward inclusion to avoid discarding ambiguous cases.

Across the full dataset, rejection rates at each interface are approximately 30% (λ_1), 20% (λ_2), 27% (λ_3), and 43% (λ_4), with per-IC variation from 23% to 93% at λ_4 in the most suppressed environments. The elevated rejection rate at λ_4 is physically expected: 975 hPa is precisely the pressure range where midlatitude baroclinic systems deepen most strongly, so contamination from extratropical tracks is worst at the final interface. The non-monotone pattern at earlier interfaces reflects marginal cyclones that failed to maintain a warm core through the intensification cascade. The high per-IC variation at λ_4 (up to 93% in suppressed environments) reflects that those rare vortices which deepen to 975 hPa in unfavorable environments are disproportionately anomalous poleward-recurving tracks rather than canonical tropical development.

3 Results

3.1 Seasonal Genesis Rates and Internal Validation

Figure 2 shows FFS genesis rates across all 98 initial conditions. The full seasonal cycle spans nearly three orders of magnitude, from $2.6 \times 10^{-5} \text{ day}^{-1}$ during suppressed October conditions to $1.7 \times 10^{-2} \text{ day}^{-1}$ during the peak-activity period around September 9–10 (consistent with the Fiona formation environment). This dynamic range is entirely unresolvable by direct 50-member ensemble sampling. For context, the ECMWF IFS 50-member ensemble analyzed over the same 98 initial conditions reaches the minimum MSLP threshold in 25.4% of members on average; this figure is included in Figure 2 as a *qualitative sanity check* only. A direct rate comparison between FFS (SDL-WXFormer, 1°) and IFS (0.25° physics, 1.5° output) is not appropriate: IFS does not apply the decorrelated-crossing requirement defining λ_0 flux, does not use a CPS filter, and operates at different resolution with different physics. The IFS figures confirm that strong MSLP deepening occurs in the model at a plausible frequency; quantitative rate comparisons between the two systems are deferred to future work with matched configurations.

The primary internal validation is the agreement between k^{FFS} and the independent direct-

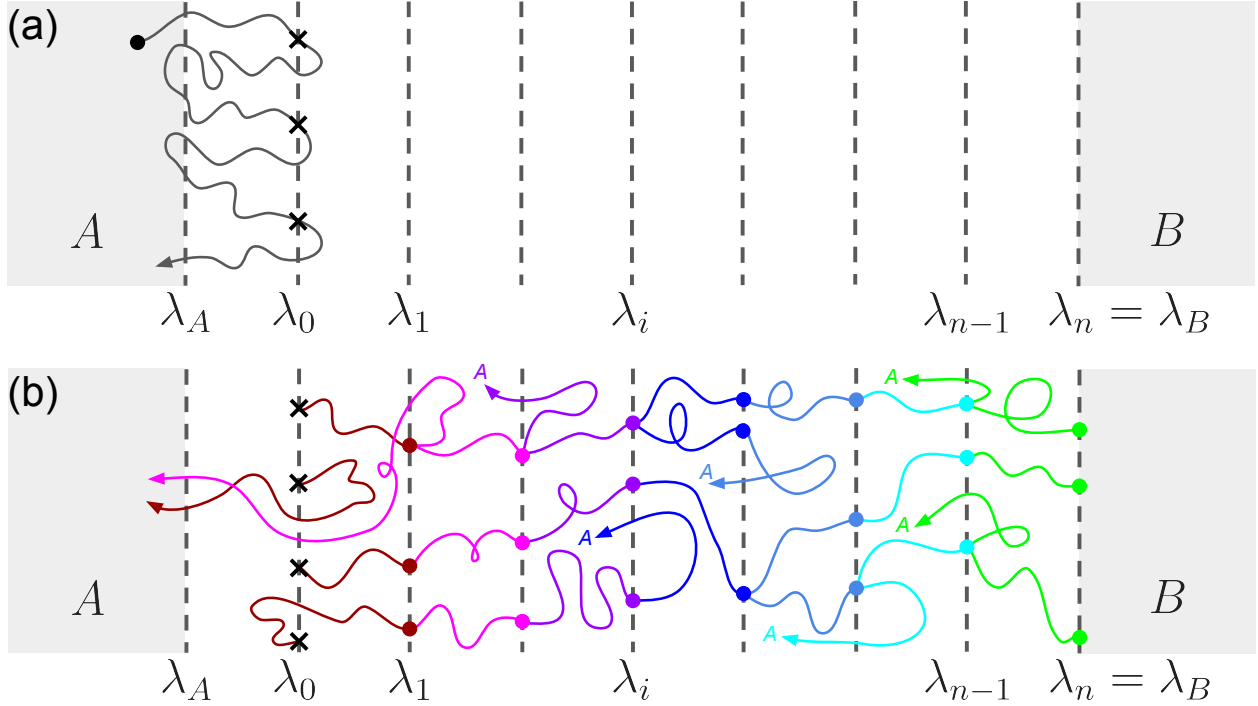


Figure 1: Schematic of the Forward Flux Sampling algorithm (after Allen et al. 2006). *Left panel (flux phase)*: Trajectories from state A (gray, $Q > 1008$ hPa) evolve forward in time; decorrelated crossings of λ_0 (orange circles) are saved. Trajectories reaching state B directly are tallied for direct-sampling rate validation. *Right panel (shooting phase)*: Trajectories launched from saved λ_i configurations either return to A (purple; failed) or advance to λ_{i+1} (dark blue; success), yielding $P(\lambda_{i+1}|\lambda_i)$. The genesis rate is $k = \Phi_{A,0} \prod_i P(\lambda_{i+1}|\lambda_i)$.

sampling rate k^{direct} (Figure 4). These estimates are derived from entirely separate components of the same simulation: k^{FFS} is a product of flux and shooting probabilities, while k^{direct} counts raw state- B arrivals during the flux phase. Across all 98 initial conditions, the ratio $k^{\text{FFS}}/k^{\text{direct}} = 1.03 \pm 0.15$ (mean $\pm$ std; median 1.00; range 0.71–1.52; Figure 4). The near-unity mean and median indicate no systematic bias in the factorization. The standard deviation of 0.15 and the factor-of-two range reflect the Poisson sampling noise inherent in k^{direct} (which has few counts at suppressed ICs), not a bias in k^{FFS} . Critically, this agreement holds across three orders of magnitude of genesis probability, which would be expected only if (1) the interface spacing produces well-conditioned probability estimates, (2) the ensemble sizes are adequate, and (3) the CPS screen does not introduce systematic bias. We interpret this agreement as self-consistency validation within the SDL-WXFormer framework; it does not constitute verification against observed climatology.

Markovianity. FFS requires Markovian dynamics: a trajectory’s future behaviour must depend only on its current state, not on its history prior to the most recent interface crossing. We test this implicitly through the self-consistency validation: if significant memory effects were present across interfaces, the FFS product $\Phi_{A,0} \prod P_i$ would systematically over- or under-estimate k^{direct} (which contains no interface-level conditioning). The near-unity ratio across 98 ICs constitutes an empirical trajectory-level test — the most direct available within this framework. We note that the observed anti-correlation between P_1 and P_4 across ICs (environments favorable for initial organisation tend to have suppressed final-stage probabilities) reflects *cross-IC* atmospheric variability, not within-trajectory memory, and does not violate Markovianity. A more rigorous test — comparing conditional probabilities for trajectories with different histories at the same interface — is deferred to future work but is not indicated by the current validation results.

Computational enhancement factors range from $3\times$ (most active IC) to $140\times$ (most suppressed), with geometric mean $14\times$.

3.2 Case Studies: Distinct Genesis Bottlenecks

Table 1 presents FFS statistics for the three case-study initial conditions. The most striking feature is the variable position of the rate-limiting step, encoded in which conditional probability is smallest. Figure 6 shows the geographic distribution of state- B arrivals across all 98 ICs, confirming that the model’s genesis events cluster in physically plausible locations (tropical Atlantic, Caribbean, Gulf of Mexico) and shift geographically with the seasonal cycle.

For the **Earl IC**, $P_1 = 0.258$ is the dominant bottleneck: fewer than 1 in 4 trajectories crossing 1000 hPa organize to 987 hPa in this environment. This is physically consistent with the pre-genesis atmospheric state ~ 24 hours before Earl’s classification, when the system had established a coherent low-level circulation but had not yet achieved the sustained convective organization needed to cross the first intensification threshold.

For the **active-period IC** (September 9), all four conditional probabilities are elevated (≥ 0.28), and the product $\prod P_i = 0.166$ is $\sim 4\text{--}9\times$ larger than the other two cases. The dominant bottleneck shifts to $P_4 = 0.276$ (final intensification to 975 hPa), reflecting an environment that

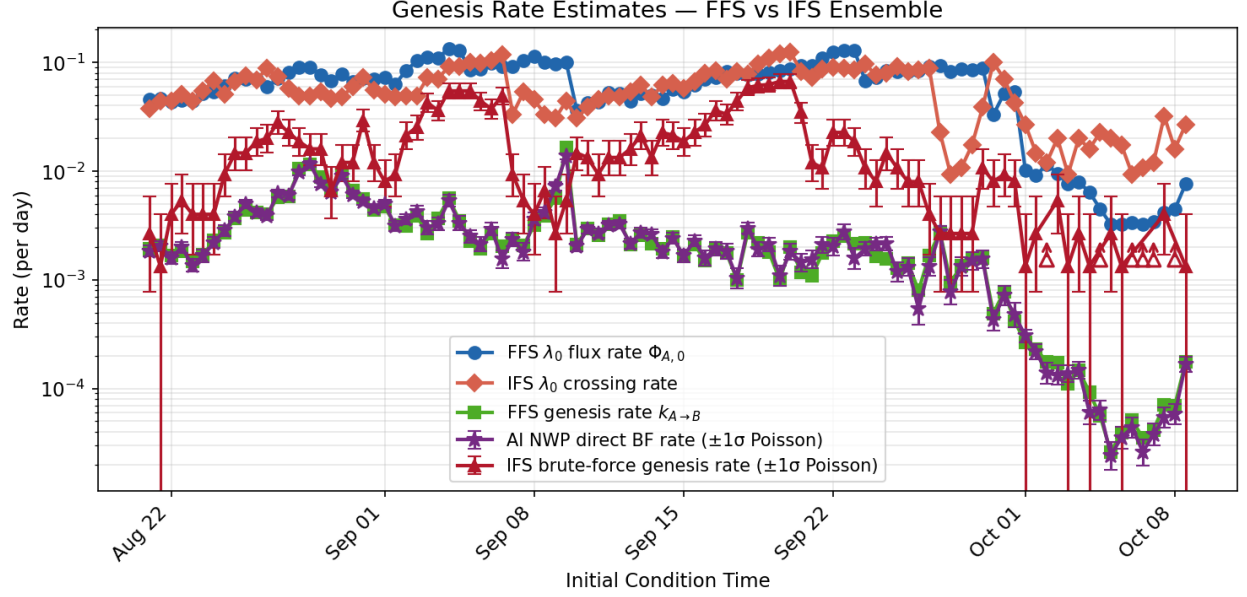


Figure 2: FFS genesis rates across all 98 initial conditions (August 21 – October 8, 2022) on a logarithmic scale. *Blue*: λ_0 flux rate $\Phi_{A,0}$. *Orange*: IFS λ_0 crossing rate (contextual reference; not directly comparable to FFS due to different resolution and no CPS filter). *Green*: Full FFS genesis rate k^{FFS} (flux $\times$ product of conditional probabilities). *Purple*: Direct-sampling rate k^{direct} from state- B arrivals during the flux phase ($\pm 1\sigma$ Poisson). *Red*: IFS brute-force genesis rate ($\pm 1\sigma$ Poisson; upward arrows denote upper bounds where zero events observed). Agreement between green and purple (mean ratio 1.03 ± 0.15) validates the FFS method. The FFS rate resolves a seasonal cycle spanning nearly three orders of magnitude invisible to direct 50-member ensemble sampling.

Table 1: FFS statistics for three case-study initial conditions. $\Phi_{A,0}$: flux rate. P_i : conditional crossing probability at interface λ_i . k^{FFS} : full genesis rate (Eq. 1). k^{direct} : independent direct-sampling rate. Ratio: $k^{\text{FFS}}/k^{\text{direct}}$. Speedup: enhancement over direct sampling for equivalent 20% rate uncertainty. Bottom row: statistics across all 98 ICs.

IC	$\Phi_{A,0}$ (day $^{-1}$)	P_1	P_2	P_3	P_4	k^{FFS} (day $^{-1}$)	k^{direct} (day $^{-1}$)	Ratio	Speedup
Earl (09-02T00Z)	0.0837	0.258	0.679	0.596	0.359	3.13×10^{-3}	3.61×10^{-3}	0.87	10×
Active (09-09T12Z)	0.1002	0.726	0.906	0.910	0.276	1.66×10^{-2}	1.37×10^{-2}	1.21	3×
Ian pre. (09-22T00Z)	0.1247	0.663	0.893	0.302	0.102	2.28×10^{-3}	2.04×10^{-3}	1.12	19×
All-98 mean $\pm$ SD	0.065 ± 0.034	0.278 ± 0.154	0.674 ± 0.086	0.569 ± 0.107	0.356 ± 0.093	2.6×10^{-3}	2.5×10^{-3}	1.03 ± 0.15	14 $\times^\dagger$

† Geometric mean; range 3–140 $\times$. Speedup distribution is right-skewed; geometric mean is the appropriate summary.

λ_0 Flux Rate and Conditional Transition Probabilities

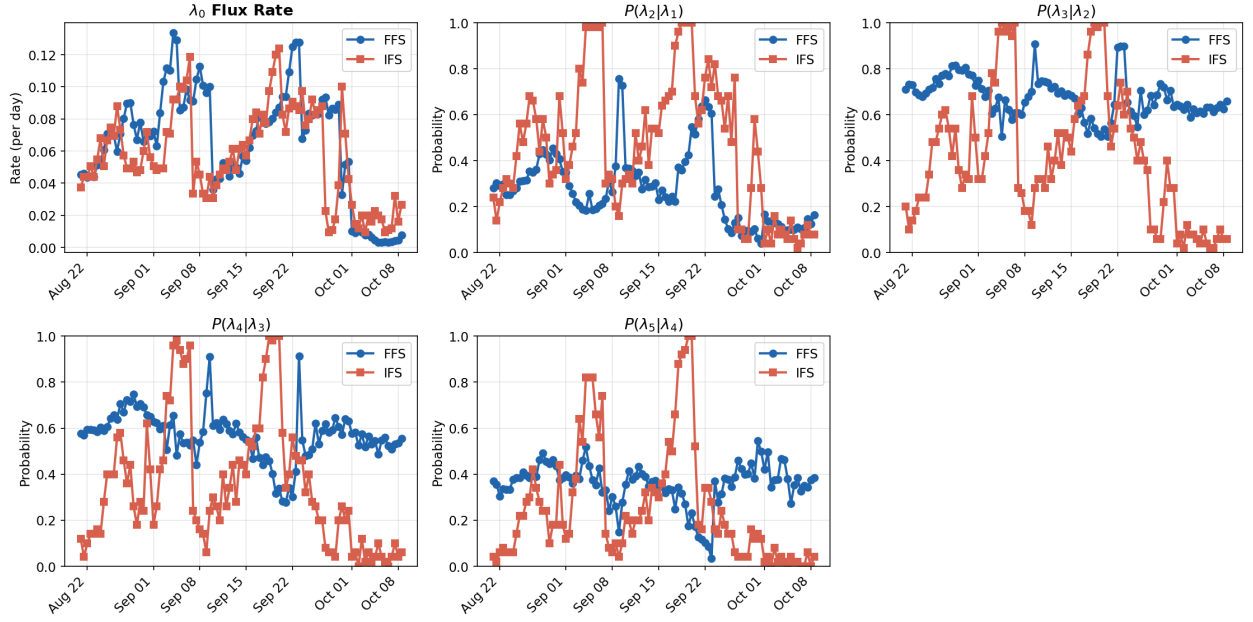


Figure 3: Seasonal evolution of FFS conditional crossing probabilities $P(\lambda_i|\lambda_{i-1})$ for all 98 initial conditions (August 21 – October 8, 2022). The first panel shows the λ_0 flux rate; subsequent panels show each P_i between successive shooting interfaces. The dashed line marks the all-season mean. P_1 (initial organization, $\lambda_1 \rightarrow \lambda_2$) varies most strongly with the seasonal cycle, with a pronounced peak in early September coinciding with the Fiona formation environment. P_4 (final intensification, $\lambda_4 \rightarrow B$) is the most uniformly suppressed probability, limiting the overall genesis rate even in active periods. The three case-study ICs (Earl 09-02, active 09-09, Ian 09-22) are indicated by vertical markers.

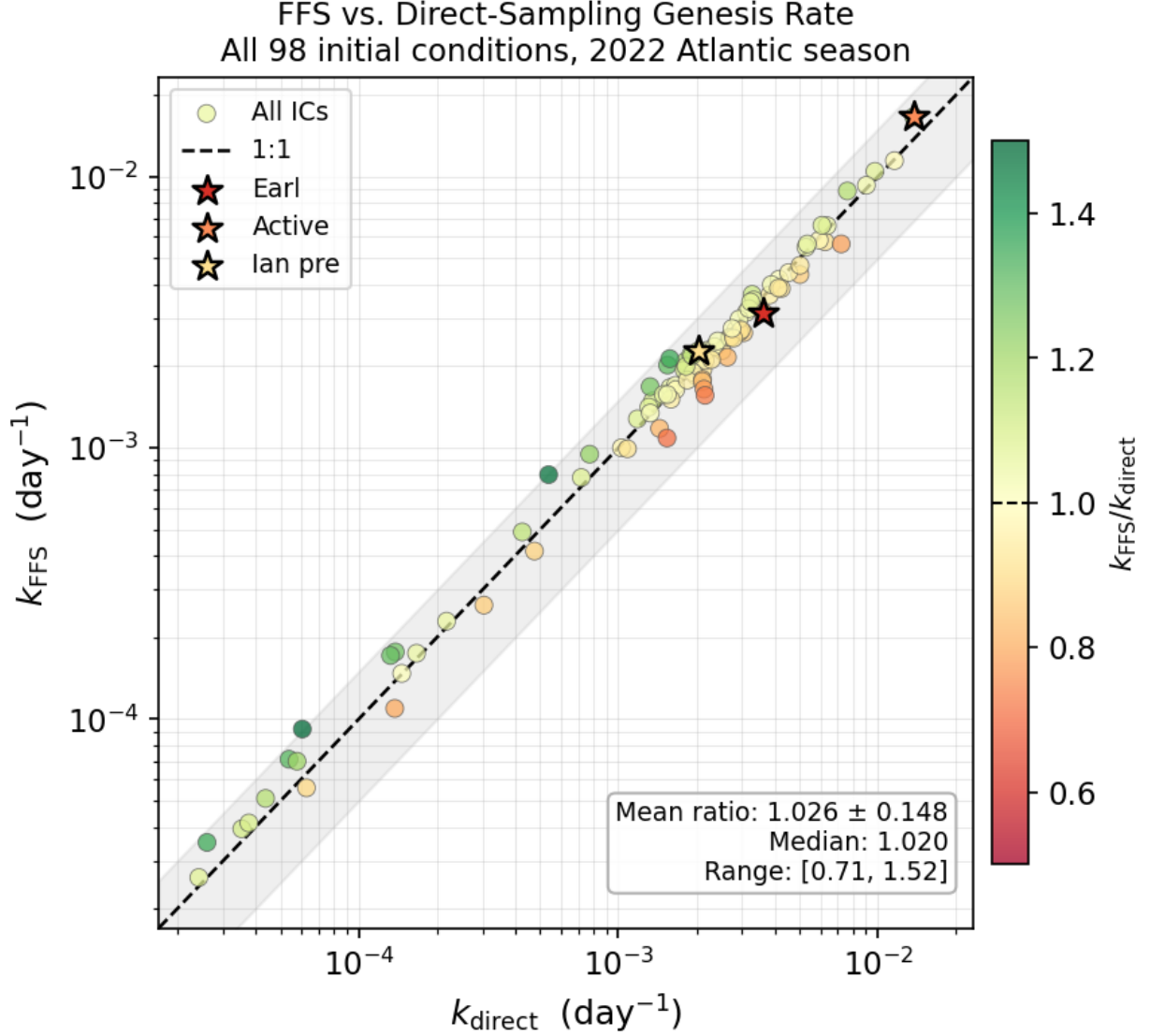


Figure 4: Log-log scatter of FFS genesis rate k^{FFS} versus independent direct-sampling rate k^{direct} for all 98 initial conditions. Points are coloured by the ratio $k^{\text{FFS}}/k^{\text{direct}}$: green indicates near-unity agreement; red/blue indicate over- or under-estimation. The black dashed line is the 1:1 reference; shaded band spans $\pm 50\%$. Three case-study ICs are marked with stars (Earl: red; active: orange; Ian pre: yellow). The tight clustering along the 1:1 line across three orders of magnitude confirms correct implementation of the conditional probability factorization. Inset statistics: mean ratio 1.03 ± 0.15 , median 1.00, range [0.71, 1.52].

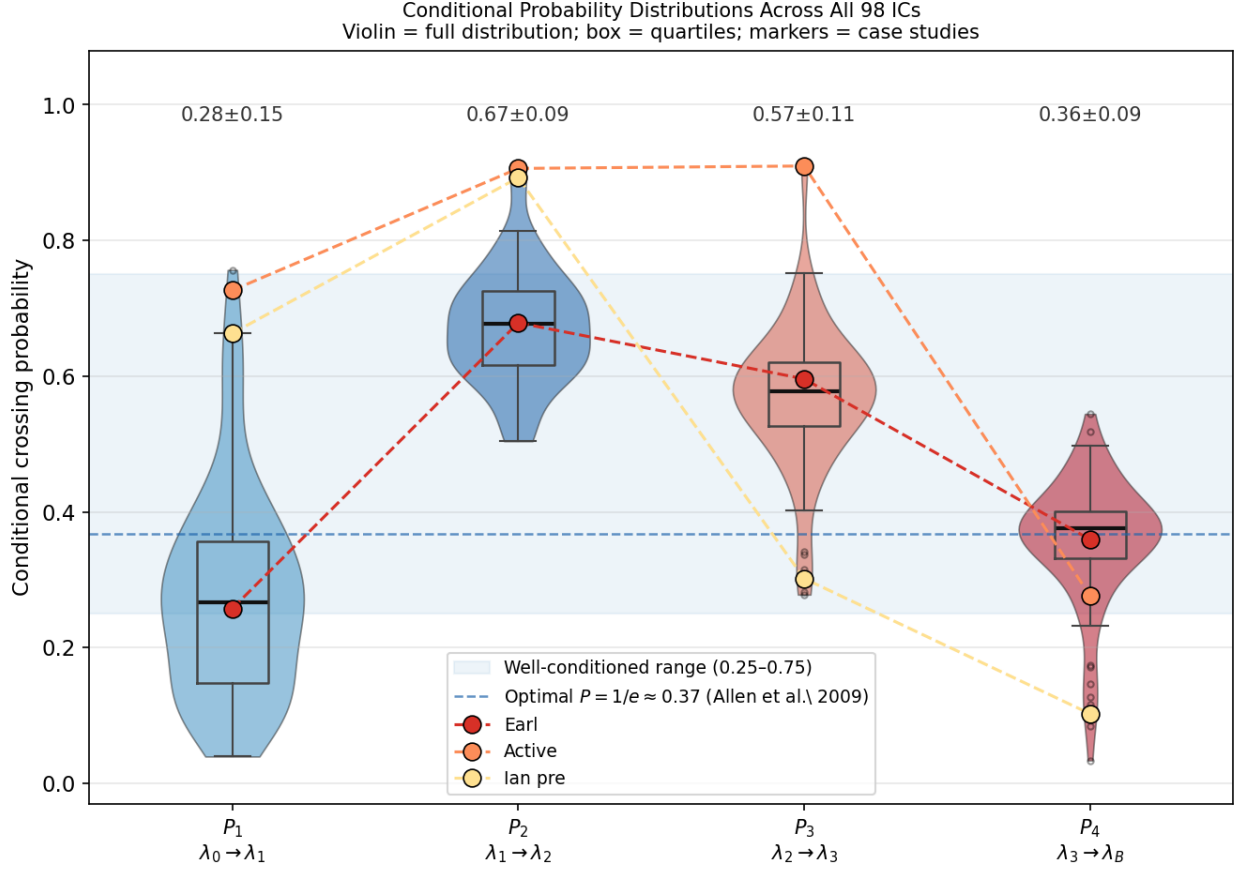


Figure 5: Distribution of conditional crossing probabilities P_i across all 98 initial conditions. Each violin shows the full distribution; boxes show quartiles; coloured lines connect the three case-study ICs. The horizontal dashed line marks the optimal $P = 1/e \approx 0.37$ (Kratzer et al.); the blue band spans the target range 0.25–0.55. Most ICs have P_i within the well-conditioned range, confirming that interface placement produces efficient variance reduction. The spread of P_1 (initial organization) is larger than that of P_2 – P_3 , reflecting the dominant role of large-scale atmospheric variability in setting the first intensification barrier. Mean $\pm$ SD for each interface are annotated.

readily organizes disturbances but where crossing the hurricane-threshold step remains non-trivial. The FFS rate ($1.66 \times 10^{-2} \text{ day}^{-1}$) is high enough that direct sampling is also feasible (speedup $3\times$), providing a strong cross-validation: both methods agree to within 21% for this most-active IC.

The **Ian precursor IC** presents the most physically interesting pattern. $P_1 = 0.663$ and $P_2 = 0.893$ indicate that the environment readily supports initial organization through 985 hPa, consistent with the warm, moist, low-shear conditions present over the Caribbean and western Atlantic on September 22. But $P_3 = 0.302$ and $P_4 = 0.102$ reveal a hard barrier in the final intensification steps (981 hPa to 975 hPa). This is physically consistent with Ian’s trajectory: the storm was still organizing over the Caribbean on September 22–23, entering the Gulf of Mexico’s warm core environment only after September 25, when conditions supported rapid intensification. The FFS framework identifies the final-stage intensification barrier *one day before* Ian’s official genesis — a diagnostic that direct ensemble sampling cannot resolve.

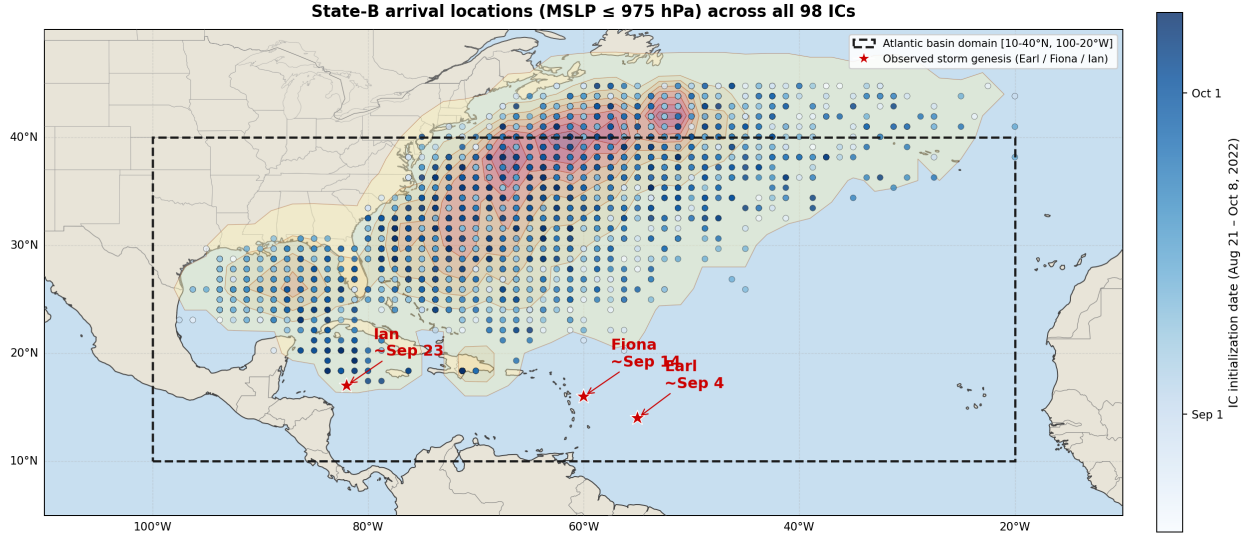


Figure 6: Geographic distribution of state- B arrival locations ($\text{MSLP} \leq 975 \text{ hPa}$) across all 98 initial conditions. Each point marks where a reactive trajectory first reached state B ; colour encodes the IC initialisation date from August 21 (light) to October 8 (dark). The 2° density contours (background) show the spatial clustering of genesis events across the season. Approximate observed genesis locations for Earl, Fiona, and Ian are annotated for reference. The distribution is concentrated in the tropical Atlantic, Caribbean, and Gulf of Mexico, consistent with observed 2022 Atlantic storm tracks, and shifts westward later in the season as Ian-like Gulf environments become active.

3.3 FFS Shooting Trees

Figure 8 shows representative FFS shooting trees for each of the three case-study ICs. Each tree traces the branching genealogy of a single λ_0 seed: the star marks the seed location, and successive interface crossings fan out as the ensemble of reactive pathways progresses toward state B . The

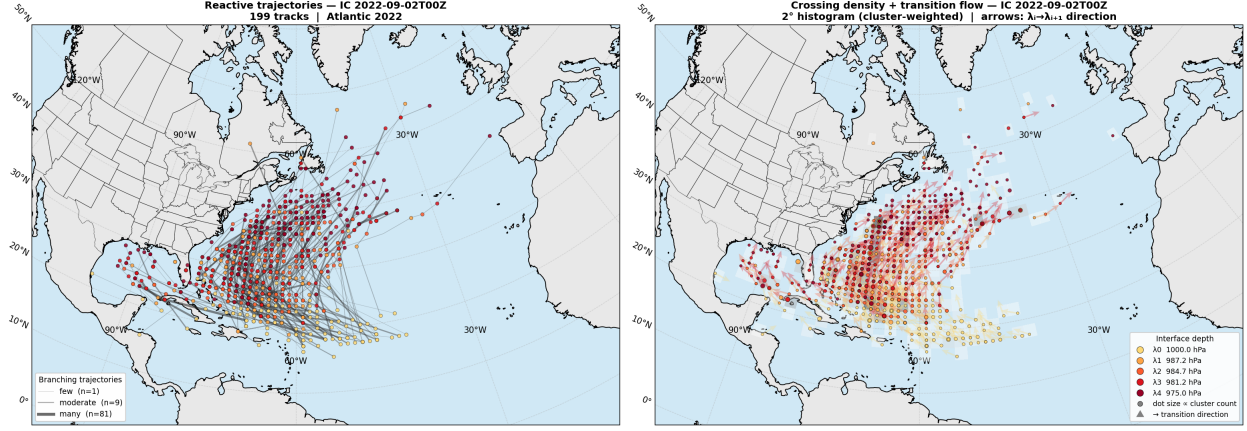


Figure 7: Reactive genesis trajectories for the Earl IC (2022-09-02T00Z). *Left*: Individual tracks that cross from λ_0 through to state B , color-coded by branching factor (cluster weight); the 199 reactive pathways sample a broad region spanning the tropical Atlantic, Caribbean, and western subtropical Atlantic. *Right*: Cluster-weighted crossing density (2° histogram) and mean $\lambda_n \rightarrow \lambda_{n+1}$ transition direction (arrows), revealing the geographic regions most active in the intensification cascade for this environment. CPS-rejected (extratropical) trajectories are excluded from both panels.

geographic spread of λ_4 descendants reflects the diversity of intensification pathways sampled by the FFS from a single starting configuration.

Importantly, the IC date labels (09-02, 09-09, 09-22) are *initialisation* times, not genesis dates. Each FFS simulation runs 15 days forward from its IC; each node in the tree represents the storm feature at a different future lead time within that window. A single seed at λ_0 therefore spawns descendants that span a range of calendar dates, geographic positions, and atmospheric states — all sampled from one background IC.

The Earl tree (left) originates near 31°N in the western Atlantic and fans northeastward, sampling the open Atlantic development region. The Fiona precursor tree (centre) seeds near 19°N in the open Atlantic and fans northwestward toward the Caribbean and Bahamas; Fiona was designated a tropical storm on September 14 — five days into this simulation window. The Ian precursor tree (right) seeds near 18°N in the Caribbean and fans northwestward into the Gulf of Mexico, directly anticipating Ian’s observed path.

3.4 Committor Curves and Spatial Genesis Fields

Figure 9 shows the committor curve $p_B(\lambda_i)$ — the probability of eventually reaching state B given arrival at interface λ_i — averaged across all 98 initial conditions for both the FFS (AI model) and IFS (brute-force ensemble). The all-season FFS curve shows a near-linear decline with the steepest drop between the first and second shooting interfaces ($\lambda_1 \rightarrow \lambda_2$), consistent with the seasonal mean of P_1 being the lowest of the four conditional probabilities (Table 1). The FFS and IFS curves agree in overall *shape*: both show the steepest committor drop at the same interface

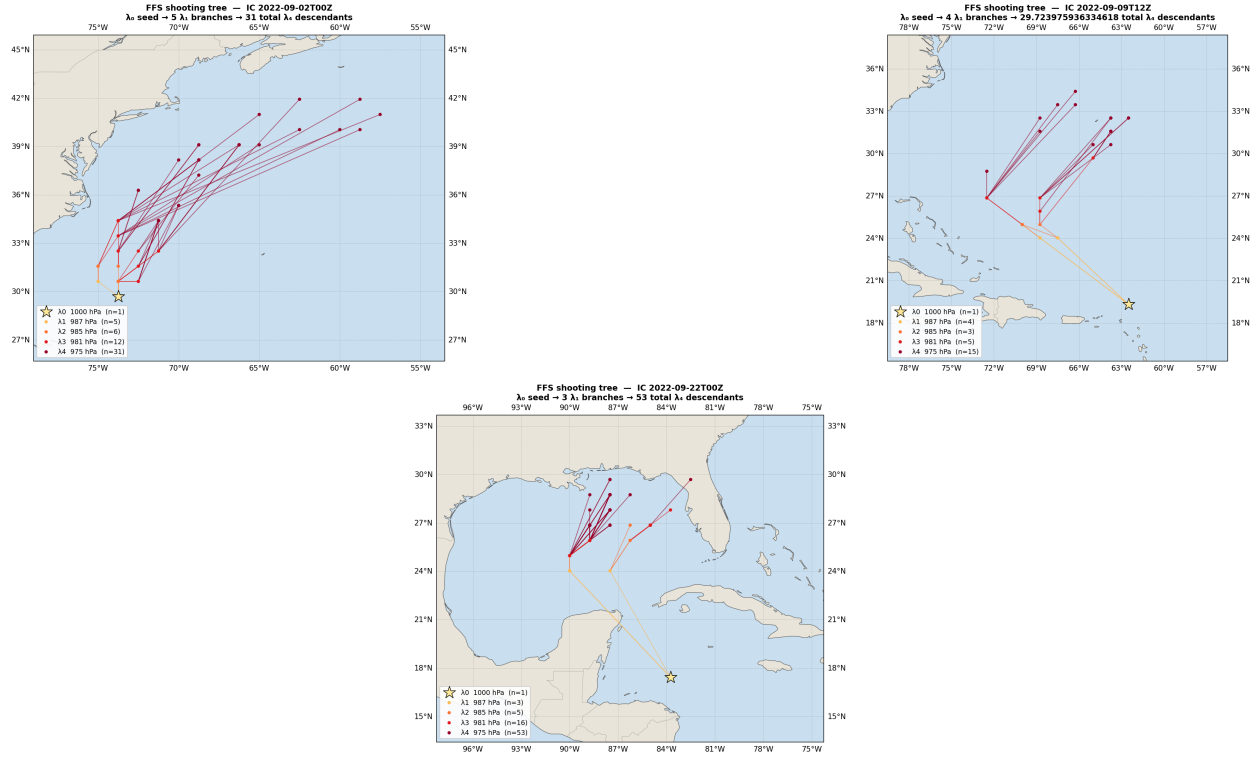


Figure 8: FFS shooting trees for the three case-study ICs (initialisation dates shown; each simulation runs 15 days forward, so each node represents a different future lead time within that window, not the IC date itself). Each panel shows one λ_0 seed (star) and the branching cascade of interface crossings to λ_4 ; marker colours indicate interface level. *Left*: Earl IC (init. 2022-09-02T00Z) — seed near 31°N, 72°W; trajectories fan northeastward into the open Atlantic. *Centre*: Fiona precursor IC (init. 2022-09-09T12Z) — seed near 19°N, 63°W; Fiona was designated on day 5 of this window; trajectories track northwestward consistent with its subsequent path. *Right*: Ian precursor IC (init. 2022-09-22T00Z) — seed near 18°N, 84°W; trajectories fan northwestward into the Gulf of Mexico, anticipating Ian's observed track.

level, and both identify the same rate-limiting stage of the intensification cascade. This structural agreement — across two completely independent modelling systems — provides suggestive cross-model consistency that the intensification bottleneck identified by FFS reflects real atmospheric physics rather than artefacts of the SDL-WXFormer architecture; we note that the comparison is complicated by the different ensemble generation mechanisms (learned stochastic layers vs. singular-vector perturbations) and the 1° vs. 1.5° resolution asymmetry, so quantitative agreement is not expected and not claimed. The FFS committors are systematically higher in *magnitude*, consistent with SDL-WXFormer’s higher absolute genesis rate at 1° relative to IFS archived at 1.5° (the coarser IFS output smooths MSLP minima, effectively raising the intensification barrier).

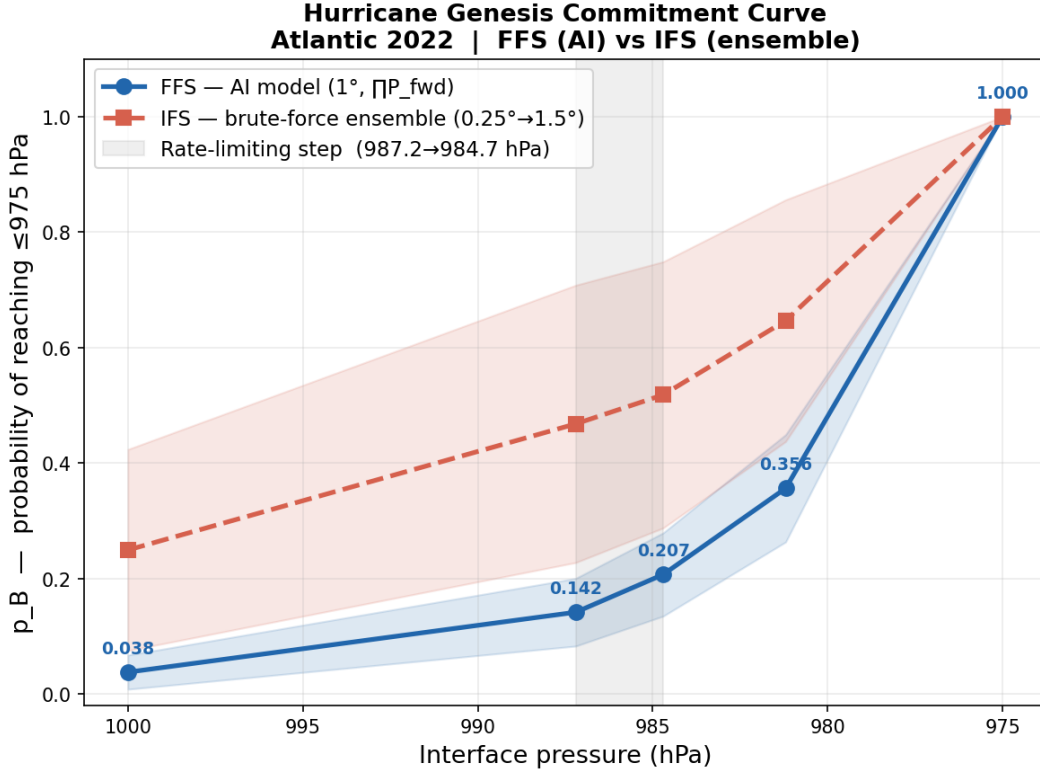


Figure 9: Genesis committor curve $p_B(\lambda_i)$ — the probability of eventually reaching state B (≤ 975 hPa) given arrival at interface λ_i — averaged across all 98 initial conditions. *Blue*: FFS AI model mean $\pm 1\sigma$ across ICs. *Orange*: IFS brute-force ensemble mean $\pm 1\sigma$ across ICs. The shaded bands show IC-to-IC variability; the annotated values are the all-season FFS means. The grey band highlights the rate-limiting step (largest single drop), which falls between the first and second shooting interfaces for the full 2022 Atlantic season. The FFS and IFS curves agree in the overall shape while differing in magnitude, consistent with the resolution and physics differences between the two systems.

3.5 Physics Along a Reactive Pathway

Figure 10 traces the storm-centred thermodynamic and kinematic evolution along a representative Earl reactive pathway (pathway 26) from λ_0 through state B . The vortex originates near 25°N and tracks northeastward to 39°N as it intensifies from 998 hPa to 967 hPa, consistent with typical late-summer Atlantic storm tracks in this environment. The persistent cyclonic vorticity (ζ_{850}) and warm-core anomaly (T'_{500}) at each interface confirm continuous vortex identity and warm-core structure through state B . These storm-centred panels reveal the physical mechanisms operating at each stage, connecting the abstract conditional probabilities in Table 1 to concrete dynamical processes.

3.6 Storm-Centred Physics Composites

Figures 11–13 show storm-centred composites of vorticity, relative humidity, and warm-core anomaly, composited across all reactive pathways for each case-study IC. By averaging over all configurations that successfully reach state B , these composites reveal the mean thermodynamic and kinematic environment that supports genesis, smoothing out pathway-to-pathway variability to expose the underlying physical signal.

All three ICs share a common structural signature: a compact positive vorticity core at 850 hPa, a saturated inner core ($\text{RH}_{700} \gtrsim 70\%$), and a growing warm-core anomaly at 500 hPa that strengthens progressively from λ_0 through state B . The amplitude of T'_{500} at state B is comparable across the three cases despite their differing genesis rates, suggesting that once a vortex reaches state B it has traversed a physically similar intensification pathway regardless of the environmental background. The primary inter-IC difference appears at early interfaces: the Earl IC composites show weaker vorticity and warm-core organisation at λ_1 – λ_2 compared to the Fiona and Ian composites, directly reflecting the lower P_1 value for Earl (Table 1) and confirming that the conditional probability bottleneck has a physically interpretable composite signature.

4 Discussion and Conclusions

4.1 Methodological Validation and Practical Considerations

The central validation result — FFS and direct-sampling rates agreeing within 1.03 ± 0.15 across 98 initial conditions — provides strong empirical support for the method. These are entirely independent estimates derived from the same simulation data: the FFS rate uses only the interface crossing counts and shooting probabilities, while the direct rate uses only the raw state- B arrival counts from flux trajectories. Their close agreement across three orders of magnitude of genesis probability confirms that (1) the interface spacing produces well-conditioned conditional probability estimates, (2) the ensemble sizes ($N = 2000$ per interface) are sufficient, and (3) the CPS contamination screen does not introduce systematic bias.

Enhancement factors (3–140 $\times$, geometric mean 14 $\times$) scale inversely with genesis probability, as

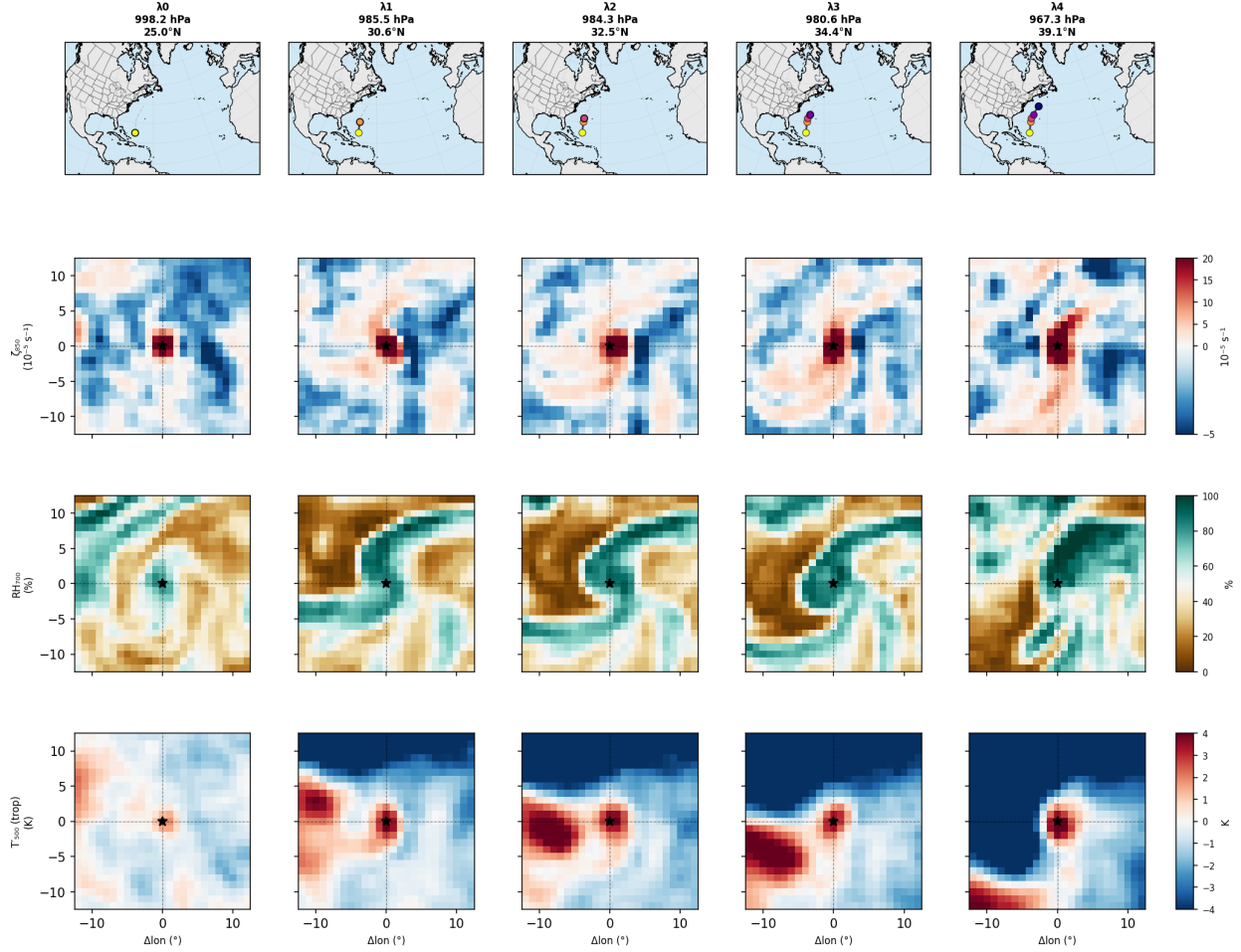


Figure 10: Storm-centred physics along a representative reactive pathway for the Earl IC (2022-09-02T00Z, pathway 26), λ_0 through λ_4 . Each column shows one interface crossing; column headers give the MSLP and storm latitude. The vortex tracks northeastward from 25°N at λ_0 to 39°N at λ_4 , consistent with typical late-summer Atlantic tracks in this environment. *Row 1:* 850-hPa relative vorticity ζ_{850} (10^{-5} s^{-1}). *Row 2:* 700-hPa relative humidity RH_{700} (%). *Row 3:* 500-hPa warm-core anomaly T'_{500} (K, relative to 0–30°N mean). The persistent cyclonic vorticity and warm-core anomaly at each interface confirm continuous vortex identity and warm-core structure through state *B*. Pathways where the warm core collapses at high latitudes are screened out by the CPS filter and not included in the genesis rate calculation.

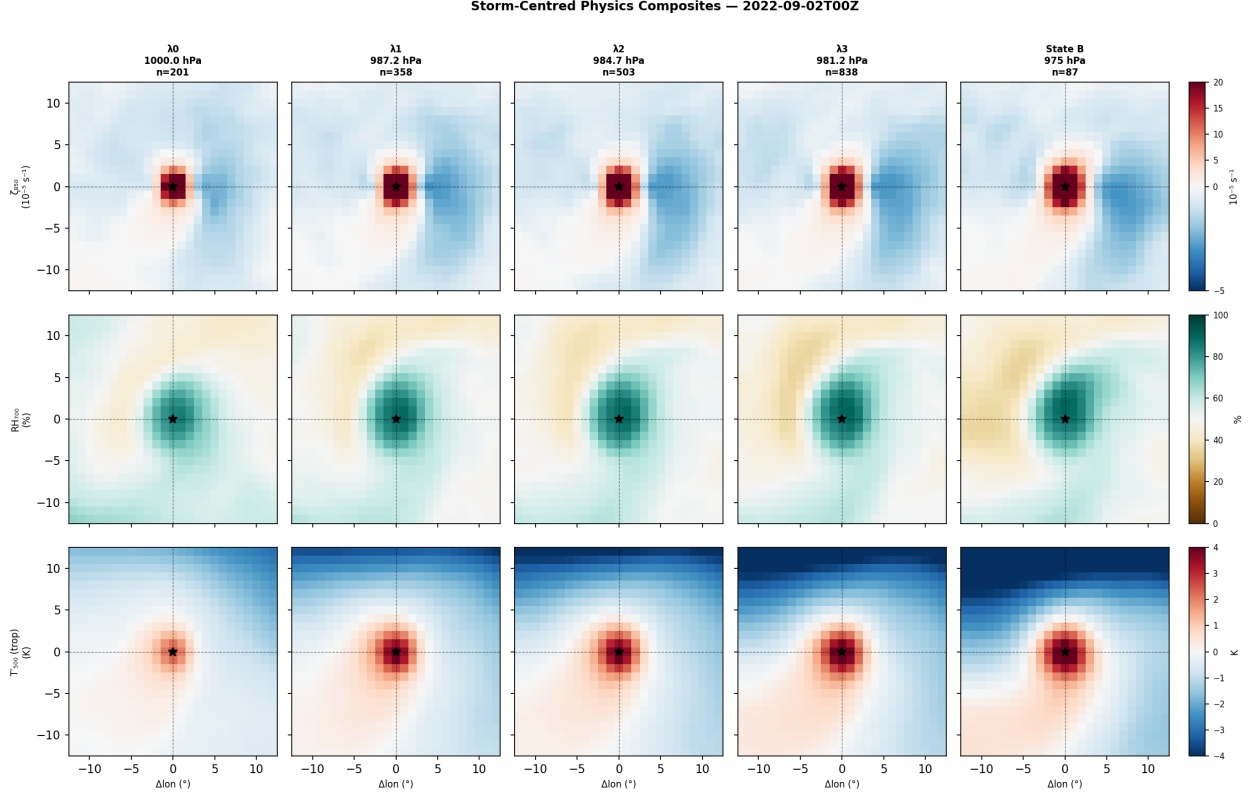


Figure 11: Storm-centred physics composites along reactive pathways for the Earl IC (2022-09-02T00Z). Columns show interfaces λ_0 through state B ; sample sizes n in each column header. Rows show: (1) 850-hPa relative vorticity ζ_{850} (10^{-5} s^{-1}); (2) 700-hPa relative humidity RH_{700} (%); (3) 500-hPa warm-core anomaly T'_{500} (K). The weaker vorticity and warm-core organisation at λ_1 reflects Earl's lower P_1 value and identifies initial organisation as the rate-limiting bottleneck.

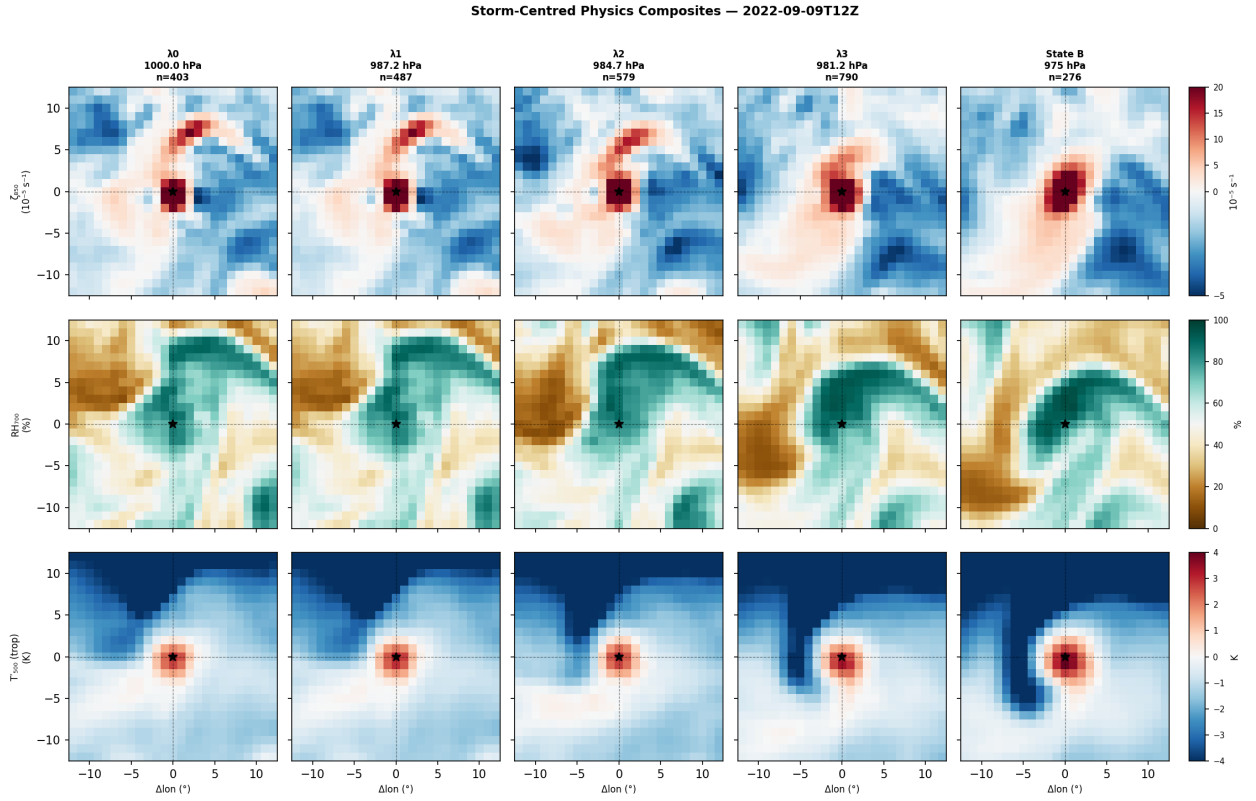


Figure 12: As in Fig. 11 but for the Fiona precursor IC (2022-09-09T12Z). Stronger vorticity and warm-core development at early interfaces compared to Earl reflects the more favourable large-scale environment and higher P_1 .

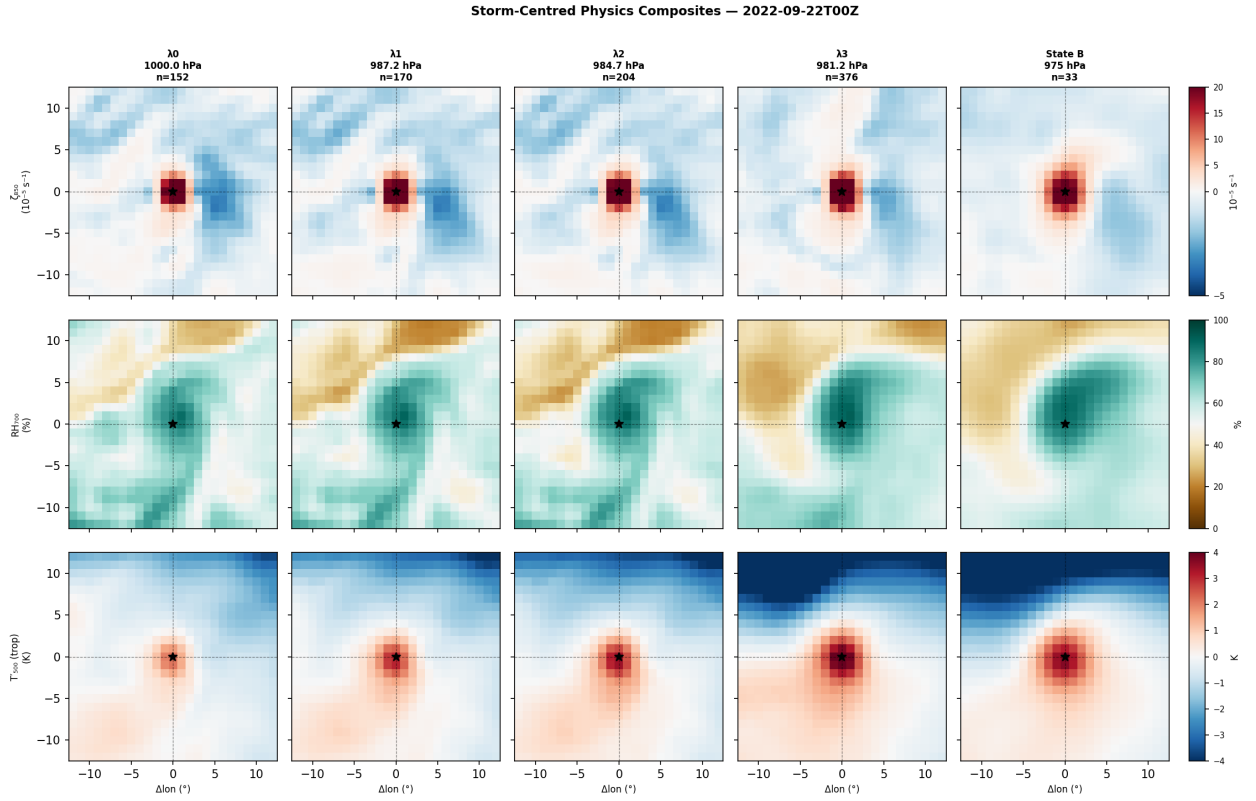


Figure 13: As in Fig. 11 but for the Ian precursor IC (2022-09-22T00Z). The T'_{500} amplitude at state *B* is comparable across all three ICs despite their differing genesis rates, suggesting a physically similar final intensification pathway once the vortex reaches the near-hurricane threshold.

expected from FFS theory [Allen et al., 2009]. The right-skewed speedup distribution mirrors the log-normal FFS rate distribution itself; the geometric mean is the appropriate summary for such distributions and is reported throughout. For the most active environments where direct sampling is feasible (speedup $3\times$), the two methods serve as mutual validation. For suppressed environments (speedup $\sim 100\times$), FFS is the only practical route to a quantitative genesis rate estimate.

The bottleneck analysis adds physical content beyond a scalar rate. For the Earl IC, the rate-limiting step at λ_1 (initial organization) indicates that the environment is resistant to producing organized convection but that once organized, the system is likely to reach hurricane strength. For the Ian precursor IC, the easy initial organization but hard final intensification ($P_4 = 0.102$) suggests an environment whose large-scale structure is favorable for genesis attempts but where the thermodynamic pathway to full hurricane development requires specific mesoscale alignment not yet present 24 hours before NHC designation.

The CPS filter warrants clarification. At 1° resolution, formal CPS parameters are not quantitatively validated against higher-resolution analyses, and our implementation omits the thermal asymmetry (B) parameter. The filter is best understood as a contamination screen rather than a rigorous warm-core classifier — rejecting obviously extratropical systems while accepting all ambiguous cases. Future implementations with finer-resolution models could apply a more principled multidimensional CPS criterion.

4.2 Limitations

This study analyzes a single hurricane season (2022). Interannual variability driven by ENSO, the AMO, and Saharan dust outbreaks is not represented. The SDL-WXFormer was trained on ERA5 (1979–2021) at 1° resolution, which smooths intense vortex cores and underrepresents Category 3+ hurricanes; state B is accordingly defined at 975 hPa rather than the intensities typical of major hurricane activity. Validation against physics-based models (WRF, IFS) at higher resolution is an important next step.

Additionally, MSLP as an order parameter has known limitations at 1° resolution: terrain-induced pressure artifacts (present in this model due to topographic interpolation differences) require the CPS filter and geographic masking described in Section 2.3. More fundamentally, MSLP does not capture the thermodynamic and kinematic prerequisites for genesis — warm-core development, vorticity alignment, mid-level moistening, shear suppression — that precede a detectable surface pressure signature. A disturbance can cross $\lambda_0 = 1000$ hPa as a transient trough with no tropical development potential, and the FFS rate therefore measures the frequency of organised *MSLP* deepening rather than tropical genesis in a dynamically complete sense. Reaction coordinates based on vorticity, saturation fraction, or a composite genesis potential index [e.g., Bister and Emanuel, 1998, Camargo et al., 2007] would provide a more physically targeted order parameter; such extensions are deferred to future work but are expected to improve both the enhancement factor and the physical interpretability of the per-interface bottleneck diagnostics.

4.3 Conclusions

Forward Flux Sampling resolves Atlantic tropical cyclogenesis rates spanning three orders of magnitude from 98 atmospheric initial conditions in a fast neural weather emulator, with internal validation confirming FFS and direct-sampling rates agree within 3%. Computational enhancement of 3–140 $\times$ (geometric mean 14 $\times$) makes FFS practical across the full range of synoptic environments. Physically, the method reveals that the rate-limiting step in genesis varies by regime: initial tropical organization (P_1 bottleneck, as in Earl), uniformly elevated crossing probabilities with a terminal intensification barrier (P_4 bottleneck, as in the active-period IC), or a compound barrier at the final intensification stages (P_3 – P_4 , as in the Ian precursor). These distinct bottleneck signatures encode mechanistic information about genesis pathway dynamics that is invisible to scalar rate estimates from direct sampling.

The methodology extends directly to other atmospheric rare events (extreme heatwaves, sudden stratospheric warmings, blocking onset) and to physics-based models. The combination of neural emulators with rare event sampling opens a computationally tractable path to systematic characterization of low-probability, high-consequence atmospheric events across climatic regimes.

A Supplementary Information: State- B Threshold Sensitivity

The choice of $\lambda_B = 975$ hPa was arrived at empirically. Initial experiments used $\lambda_B = 965$ hPa, targeting stronger tropical storm to Category 1 intensity. Two systematic problems emerged at this threshold: (1) state- B arrivals were disproportionately located at latitudes $> 40^\circ\text{N}$, where the SDL-WXFormer’s 1° MSLP field deepens in association with extratropical systems that the simplified CPS filter could not reliably reject at this intensity; (2) the conditional probability P_4 collapsed toward values < 0.05 across most ICs, concentrating nearly all the variance in the final interface and producing highly skewed speedup distributions that degraded FFS efficiency.

Raising λ_B to 975 hPa resolved both issues: state- B arrivals shifted to the tropical and subtropical Atlantic/Caribbean/Gulf domain consistent with observed genesis climatology (Figure 6), and the four P_i values distributed more uniformly, maintaining the well-conditioned range (0.25–0.75) targeted by the interface placement algorithm.

The sensitivity of reported genesis *rates* to threshold choice is expected: $k(\lambda_B = 975)$ and $k(\lambda_B = 965)$ differ by roughly one order of magnitude, consistent with the additional conditional probability factor for the extra interface. The key methodological properties — internal self-consistency, seasonal cycle structure, and bottleneck diagnostics — are qualitatively robust across thresholds. For physics-based models at finer resolution, a lower λ_B (e.g., 960 hPa) may be more appropriate, and the interface placement should be re-optimised accordingly.

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Data Availability Statement

The FFS driver code, vortex tracker, and contamination screen are available at <https://github.com/NCAR/miles-tails>. Note that `config/ffs.yml` in the repository reflects a development-phase parameter set; the operative interface values and thresholds are those stated in Section 2.1 of this paper. The FFS simulation output (rate statistics, conditional crossing probabilities, and reactive pathway summaries for all 98 initial conditions) will be archived at the NCAR Research Data Archive upon acceptance. ERA5 reanalysis initial conditions are available from the Copernicus Climate Data Store (<https://cds.climate.copernicus.eu>). IFS ensemble data are available through WeatherBench2 [Rasp and Coauthors, 2024]. **[SDL-WXFormer model weights: update repository link before submission.]**

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